



CASE STUDY



Parent Journey and Perceptions of Infant Food

How we helped a global food & beverage brand develop a better understanding of parents and their expectations of premade infant food.

*Industry: Infant food • Markets: China, Italy, Russia, UK
Languages: Chinese (Mandarin), Italian, Russian, English*



The Challenge

Our client, a global **food & beverage company** with an infant food division, wanted to revive their infant food offering in anticipation of launching new product lines and an associated marketing campaign. In order to do this, they needed to:

- **Understand** the common milestones, emotions and experiences shared by parents of children at each stage of the journey from 0-36 months.
- **Explore** parents' perceptions of infant food in general, and of the client brand in particular.
- **Gain insight** into which of the client's key areas of focus resonated with their audience, and how.
- **Gain a view** of the key online personas present in parents' conversations on social media.



Our Solution

Data Retrieval

We used **targeted keyword searches** to identify first-person social media conversation by parents, from pregnancy through to children aged 36 months. In some cases these keywords were combined with branded or thematic terms. The searches were run through a licensed social listening tool to pull in all the relevant content for analysis.

Data Analysis & Content Coding

We **qualitatively analysed conversations** to identify overarching themes and attitudes, introducing manual evaluation of content to quantify conversation around brands and products.

Parent Journey

We **reviewed parent discussion** at each stage of their journey (e.g. pregnancy, 0-6 months) and **manually coded key elements** such as emotions experienced and parent/child milestones. We analysed this content to identify overarching themes within and across markets, giving a nuanced view of the parent experience in each country.

Perceptions of Infant Food

We **evaluated parent discussion** of pre-made infant food, **identifying the leading drivers** of advocacy and detraction for the category as a whole.

Brand & Competitor Audit

We **analysed and sized the online conversation** around pre-made infant food for the brand and its leading competitors in each market. This included **overarching perceptions**, as well as **brand positioning** and **opinions** of specific products. We also reviewed brand positioning, and the interplay of perceptions of the client's infant food brand and those of its parent brand.

Corporate Pillar Analysis

Exploring discussion of infant food in connection with three thematic pillars shared by the client, we were able to **rank** these in order of audience priority, and pull out insights into the specific elements driving enthusiasm and concern around each pillar. We produced **specific recommendations** of what to prioritise in product development.

Persona Development

Based on our review of content throughout all other stages of the research, **we developed four online persona types**. These were defined by elements such as their attitudes towards pre-made infant food, their level of experience as a parent, their online behaviours (e.g. seeking/sharing advice) and their day-to-day needs as a parent. We provided targeted recommendations on potential ways to engage or collaborate with each one.

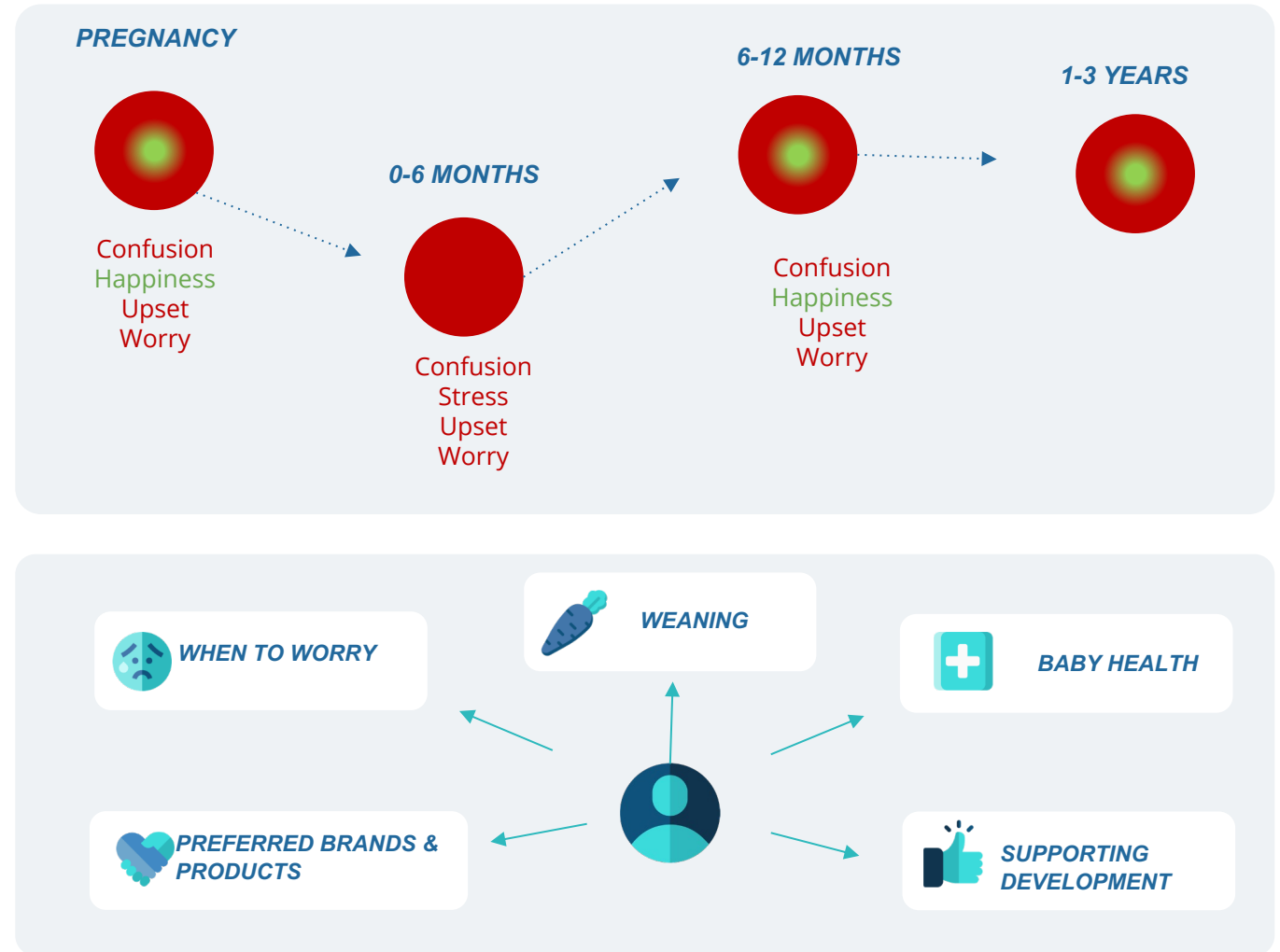
Findings (1)

Parents in China are constantly trying to balance traditional and modern scientific priorities in infant health, with respect for both.

Mothers in the UK turn to forums for support throughout the parent journey, often feeling unsupported by their partners and questioning their abilities as parents.

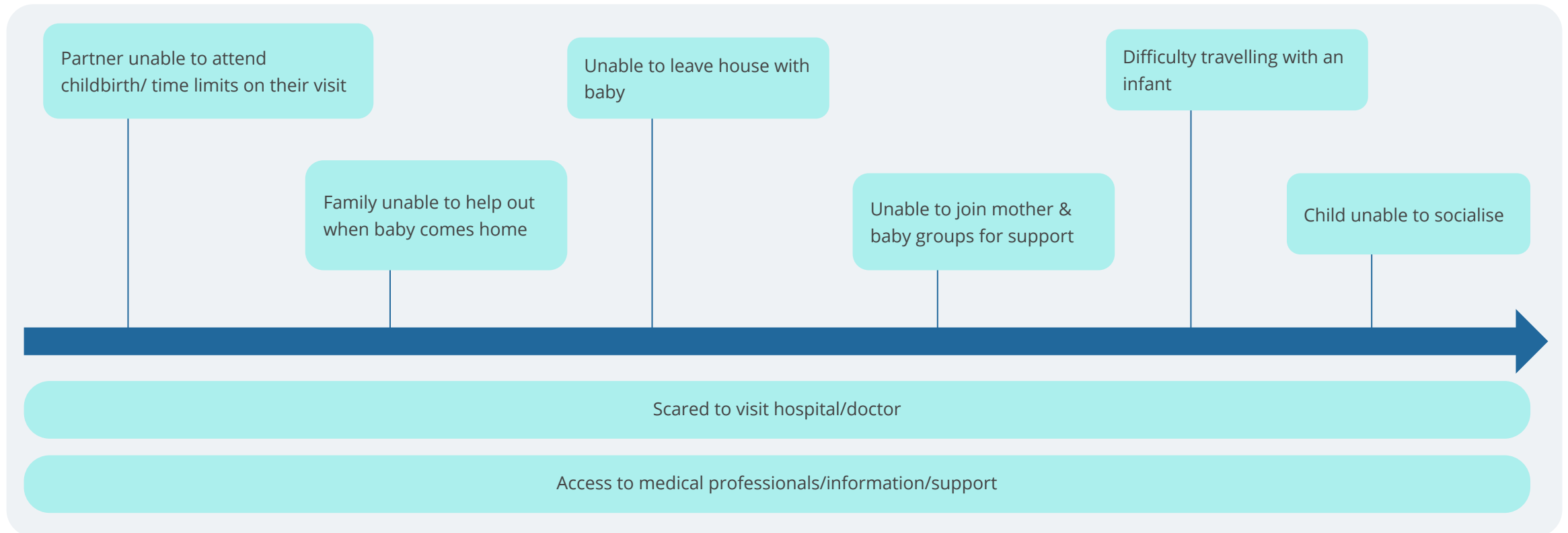
Parental conversation displays the highest levels of negative emotions when their child is aged 0-6 months, as mums and dads struggle with lack of sleep and shifting relationship dynamics.

Sustainability of products and packaging is hardly addressed within the infant food space. There is room for brands to take ownership of this growing conversation.



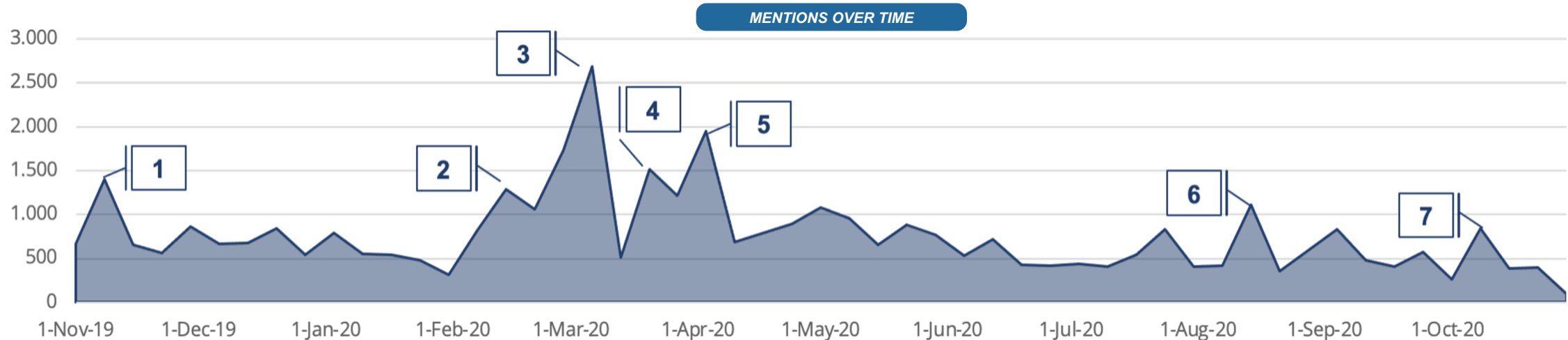
Findings (2)

The impact of Covid-19 was present throughout the parent journey, with mothers in particular feeling isolated from relatives and mother & baby groups. A lack of information on what to expect from medical providers under their new circumstances added to the confusion and distress.



Findings (3)

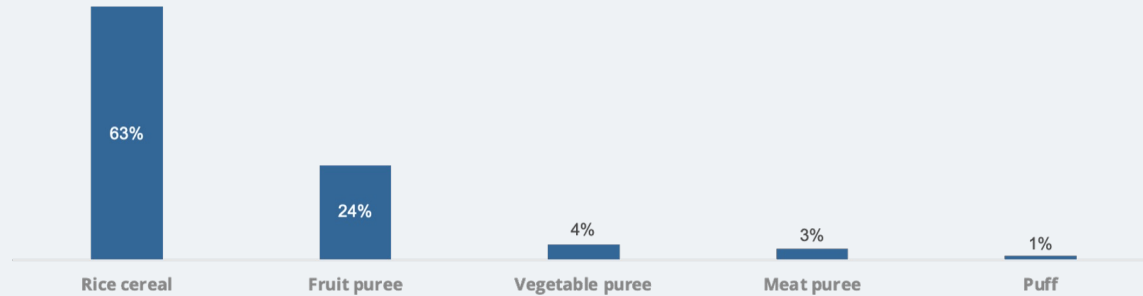
Branded content featuring collaboration with KOLs and brand giveaways drive peaks in coverage



- 1 **Recommendations of the brand's tomato ketchup** by restaurants and influencers, some of whom shared serving suggestions, such as eating it alongside fried foods.
- 2 **A video featuring the brand's sweetcorn** generated active engagement on Weibo.
- 3 **The brand's collaboration with Huabei (a consumer credit product)** generated hundreds of engagements on Weibo.
- 4 **A mum influencer's review of milk rusks**, in which the brand was listed and recommended for having no preservatives or artificial flavouring, generated positive engagement from mothers.
- 5 **A food influencer's recommendation of the brand's tomato ketchup**, and a **product giveaway** by the brand, contributed to the peak.
- 6 **Continued endorsement of the brand's tomato ketchup** by leading food influencers on Weibo. These generated hundreds of engagements.
- 7 E-commerce retailer JD.com's **product recall** of the brand's tomato purée was shared by a mother, whose post generated traction.

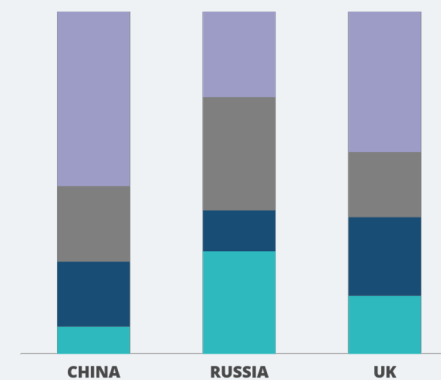
Findings (4)

MOST MENTIONED COMPETITOR PRODUCTS



Premiumisation. Parents in China and Russia have a preference for products with bright and colourful packaging, especially when it comes to sharing snacks and food with their child's playmates. It is common practice for mums to want to impress their peers and build their child's social circle by serving premium or 'high status' brands.

In terms of topic, product discussions were **dominated by the rice cereal** with parents expressing appreciation of its original flavour and high iron content.



Outcome

1 **We helped the client to understand what parents in each market are looking**
for from premade infant food products, and what makes them decide against purchasing a certain product.

2 **We identified new products attractive to** parents in each market, and how parental priorities differ from country to country.

3 **We identified the leading emotional/support needs of parents at each stage of the journey,** and offered recommendations on how to support them and build brand loyalty.

4 **All of this supported** the client's product and communications development.

Headquartered in London, UK, Convosphere is a **global business insights and intelligence agency** providing expert multilingual **Social Media Analysis** to Agencies and Enterprise for better customer understanding. We conduct Social Listening, **Multilingual Social Media Monitoring** and Social Media Analytics for global projects across all social listening tools, social platforms, channels and geographies. Our mission is to support agencies and enterprises in answering business questions and developing actionable customer insights globally. Our job is to **make your strategic social listening efforts scalable and successful**. Our Social Listening Analysts work with your project team to extend your company's language and analysis capabilities on a project or hourly basis.



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